ones, jostling and heaving with vitality. And all the pages are limned with gold, giving the album its original name, the *Muraqqa-e-Zarr-Negar*, the Album of Golden Beauty.

That Salim was using Persianate aesthetics primarily to oppose Akbar's own sensibility is clear from the fact that after he became emperor, he unceremoniously put aside both the style and the painter Aqa Riza. While Aqa Riza continued to work on the Gulshan Album, it was his son, the young Abu'l Hasan, who would become one of Salim's favourites. There is a portrait of Abu'l Hasan by Daulat, which depicts him as an intense young painter, hunched inches away from his drawing board, frowning in complete absorption. The young Abu'l Hasan quickly mastered European techniques, using a style unprecedented in Mughal India, according to Milo Beach. This incorporation of European techniques into Mughal art was what would fascinate Salim once he became Padshah Jahangir. He quickly lost interest in the flat Persianate style and enthusiastically began patronizing artists such as Abu'l Hasan. About this young artist Jahangir would write in his memoirs that '[Abu'l Hasan's] work is beyond comparison in any way to his father's. They cannot even be mentioned in the same breath… He is truly a rarity of the age.'

Despite his intense and life-long interest in paintings, Salim would maintain all his life a froideur towards the great art produced at Akbar's court, perhaps as a silent admission that art was the only field in which he considered himself equal to his illustrious father. As pointed out by historian John Seyller, when Salim inherited his father's enormous imperial library, he made numerous notes on the margins of books praising the calligraphy or the art but he never once singled out any work from Akbar's ateliers, despite the presence of hundreds of such paintings.*

In understanding the way in which Salim manipulated artistic techniques to suit his political purposes, it becomes clear that the evolution of Mughal art did not follow a simple, linear pattern from Persian stylization to European naturalism. Scholars had earlier viewed this as a criticism of Mughal art, and cavilled about its inability to truly 'master' European techniques and remaining somewhat naïve in its use. Instead, art historians like Kavita Singh have shown that Mughal artists and patrons had a much more nuanced and flexible relationship to art styles and techniques, using different forms with virtuosity and creativity as it suited them, unhindered by a European notion of a unified style over time. 'Stylistic